What Makes It Mine?

aka Art & Authorship

Session 3b: Authorship & Circulation



Philosophy of Art with Rebecca Millsop, Ph.D.

ARTIST COMMONS

How This Works

- Not a traditional philosophy class
- No argument analysis, no debating which theory is correct

The Goal:

1. Know the major theories – understand what they claim
2. Use them as tools – apply them to your own practice

Format:

- Talk + Reflection Questions + Q&A at the end
- Drop questions in the chat as we go
- Post follow ups in the community app - I'll engage there!

The Four Questions

Q1: What am I making?

"I make stuff but is it art?" →
"Here's what makes my work art and why."

Philosophical territory:
ontology and definition

Q2: How does it mean?

“I hope people understand it…” →
"Here's how my art creates meaning."

Philosophical territory:
semiotics and communication

Q3: What makes it mine?

“Everything has already been done!” →
"Here is my lineage & my contribution."

Philosophical territory:
originality and authorship

Q4: Why does it matter?

“Is my work saying anything important?” →
"Here is why my work matters."

Philosophical territory:
value and function

What Session 3a Established

✨**Genius and Exemplary Originality - Kant**

New work can open a possibility.

🧬 **Tradition and the Historical Sense - Eliot**

New work changes how tradition is seen.

↩️ **Anxiety of Influence**

Influence can change direction.

🔁 **Originality and Repetition**

Claims to newness depend on repetition.

Where Session 3a Left Us





Andy Warhol · Flowers · 1964



Sturtevant · Warhol Flowers · 1969–70





What does identifying someone **as the author** allow us to do with a work?



Today's Focus: **Four Frameworks**

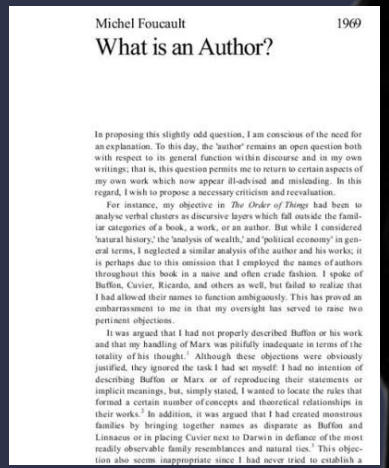
1. 🏷️ The Author as Function
2. 🧭 Situated Authorship
3. 🤝 Art as Collective Production
4. 📡 The Author as Producer

Framework 1

🏷️ The Author as Function

An author’s name does more than identify who made the work.

It helps organize how the work is understood and treated.



Michel Foucault 1969

What is an Author?

In proposing this slightly odd question, I am conscious of the need for an explanation. To this day, the 'author' remains an open question both with respect to its general function within discourse and in my own writings; that is, this question permits me to return to certain aspects of my own work which now appear ill-advised and misleading. In this regard, I wish to propose a necessary criticism and reevaluation.

For instance, my objective in *The Order of Things* had been to analyse verbal clusters as discursive layers which fall outside the familiar categories of a book, a work, or an author. But while I considered 'natural history,' the 'analysis of wealth,' and 'political economy' in general terms, I neglected a similar analysis of the author and his works; it is perhaps due to this omission that I employed the names of authors throughout this book in a naive and often crude fashion. I spoke of Buffon, Cuvier, Ricardo, and others as well, but failed to realize that I had allowed their names to function ambiguously. This has proved an embarrassment to me in that my oversight has served to raise two pertinent objections.

It was argued that I had not properly described Buffon or his work and that my handling of Marx was pitifully inadequate in terms of the totality of his thought.[1] Although these objections were obviously justified, they ignored the task I had set myself: I had no intention of describing Buffon or Marx or of reproducing their statements or implicit meanings, but, simply stated, I wanted to locate the rules that formed a certain number of concepts and theoretical relationships in their works.[2] In addition, it was argued that I had created monstrous families by bringing together names as disparate as Buffon and Linnaeus or in placing Cuvier next to Darwin in defiance of the most readily observable family resemblances and natural ties.[3] This objection also seems inappropriate since I had never tried to establish a

The Person and the Author



The person who makes the work



The artist we come to know through the work

What changes when we name the artist?



“A work by Sturtevant”

We place it within a body of work.

We approach it with particular questions.

Attribution affects how it is recognized and treated.

The Author-Function

The author-function is the *organizing role of attribution*.

Connect it to other works.



Interpret it through their practice.



Exhibit and record it as theirs.



The Artist as Shortcut

We bring expectations to an artist's work.

Those expectations can take the place of looking.

The artist does not set those expectations alone.

Martine Gutierrez



Queer Rage, Imagine Life-Size, and I'm Tyra, pp. 66–67 from *Indigenous Woman*, 2018
Crystal Bridges Museum of American Art, 2020.76. 2018, printed 2020; edition 3/8.



For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one current work.

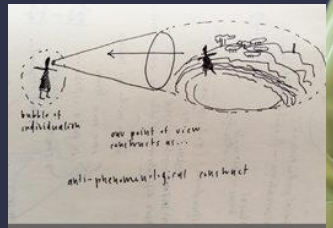
What might someone *assume* about it because it is *yours*?

Would you reinforce that expectation or interrupt it? How?

Framework 2

🧭 Situated Authorship

What you can see depends on where and how you encounter the world.



DONNA HARAWAY
Situated Knowledges: The Science Question in Feminism and the Privilege of Partial Perspective



The “god trick”

One critic, two claims

About **your** account…

“You have a perspective.”



About their own account

“I just see things as they are.”

Situated Knowledge



Situated Authorship



LaToya Ruby Frazier, Landscape of the Body (Epilepsy Test), 2011

Where it gets complicated

Does situated automatically mean *autobiographical*?

Sin Wai Kin



A Dream of Wholeness in Parts, 2021



How is this viewpoint made?





For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one current work.

What does your position let you notice?

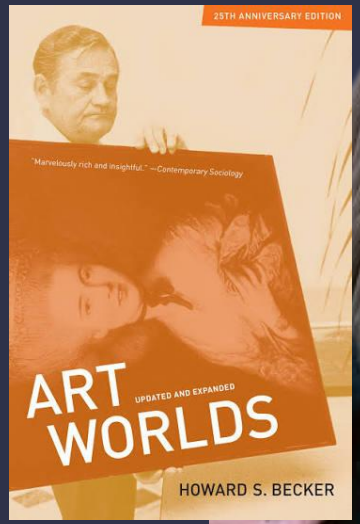
What might challenge that view?

What could change in the work as a result?

Framework 3

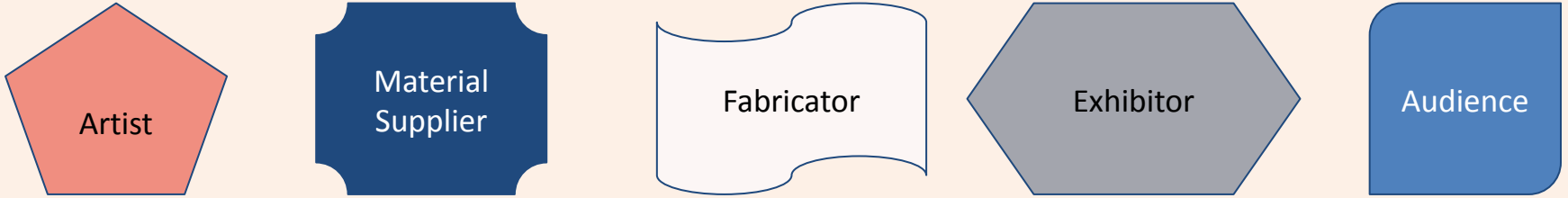
🤝 Art as Collective Production

The artist's contribution takes shape within collective activity.





Art as Collective Activity

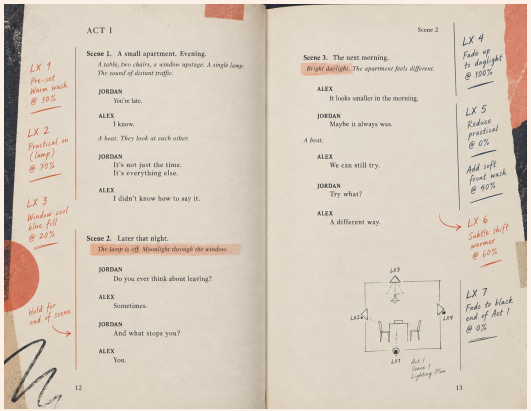


An art world:
people whose activities make a kind of art possible.

Cooperation & Possible Conventions









Which activities count as the artist's work?

Defining Work

Chooses the subject
Frames and selects the image
Select the final image

Supporting Work

Selects paper
Adjusts contrast and detail

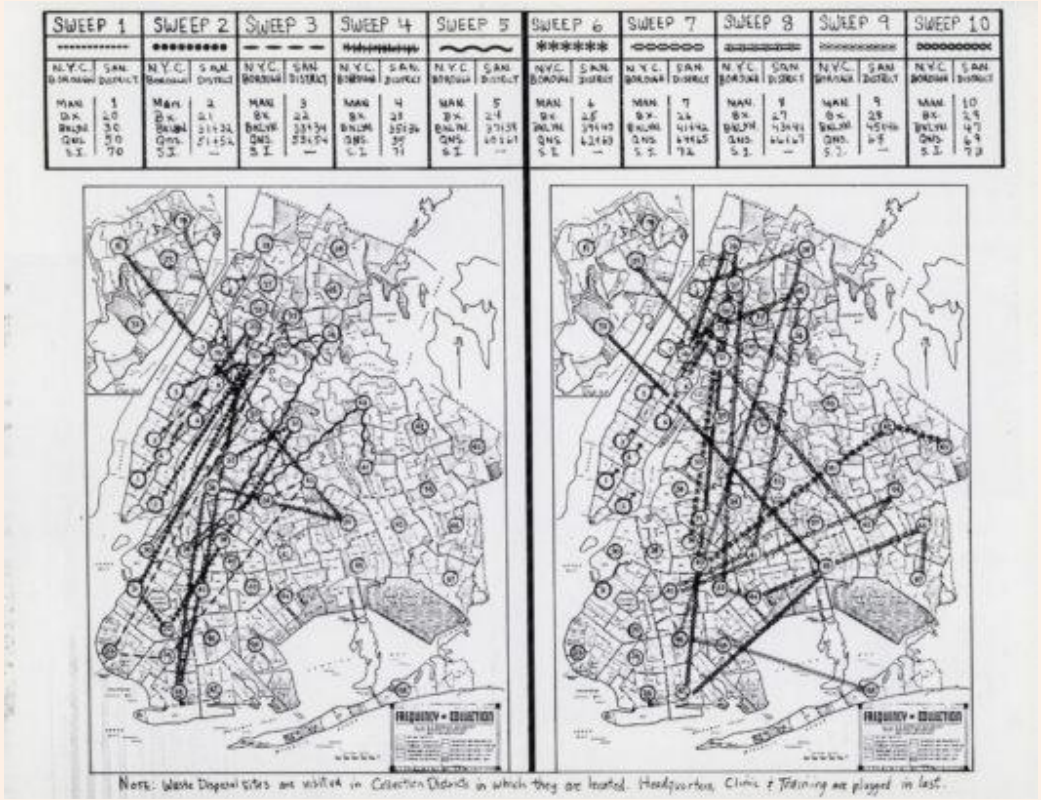
How do we distinguish
artistic work from support work?

Where it gets complicated

Collective production does not mean equal authorship.

Cooperation does not mean equal power.

Mierle Laderman Ukeles





For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one current work.

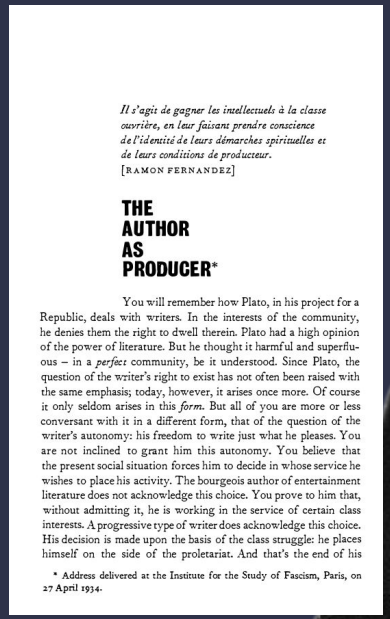
How does someone else's activity shape it?

What could you change about how the work gets made?

Framework 4

📡 The Author as Producer

What does the work do within the arrangements that produce and circulate it?



Il s'agit de gagner les intellectuels à la classe ouvrière, en leur faisant prendre conscience de l'identité de leurs démarches spirituelles et de leurs conditions de producteur.
[RAMON FERNANDEZ]

THE AUTHOR AS PRODUCER*

You will remember how Plato, in his project for a Republic, deals with writers. In the interests of the community, he denies them the right to dwell therein. Plato had a high opinion of the power of literature. But he thought it harmful and superfluous – in a *perfect* community, be it understood. Since Plato, the question of the writer's right to exist has not often been raised with the same emphasis; today, however, it arises once more. Of course it only seldom arises in this *form*. But all of you are more or less conversant with it in a different form, that of the question of the writer's autonomy: his freedom to write just what he pleases. You are not inclined to grant him this autonomy. You believe that the present social situation forces him to decide in whose service he wishes to place his activity. The bourgeois author of entertainment literature does not acknowledge this choice. You prove to him that, without admitting it, he is working in the service of certain class interests. A progressive type of writer does acknowledge this choice. His decision is made upon the basis of the class struggle: he places himself on the side of the proletariat. And that's the end of his

* Address delivered at the Institute for the Study of Fascism, Paris, on 27 April 1934.

The Author’s Position



Making

- Tools
- Skills
- Materials



Selecting / Preparing

- Editing
- Rehearsal
- Selection



Presenting / Circulating

- Exhibitions
- Performance
- Publication

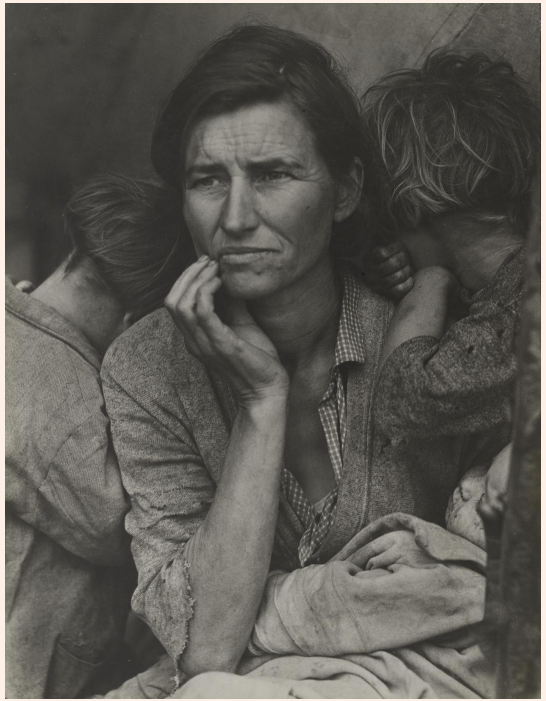


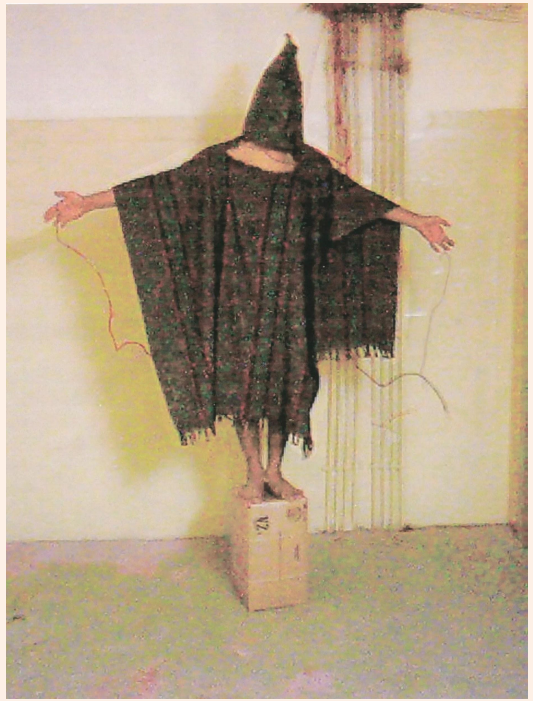
Encountering / Using

- Reading
- Responding
- Contributing

Radical Content Can Leave Things Unchanged







Technique

Technique = Procedures through which a work is made & presented



These choices about how a work is made are part of its political activity.

Enabling Others to Become Producers

What does your work enable others to make?

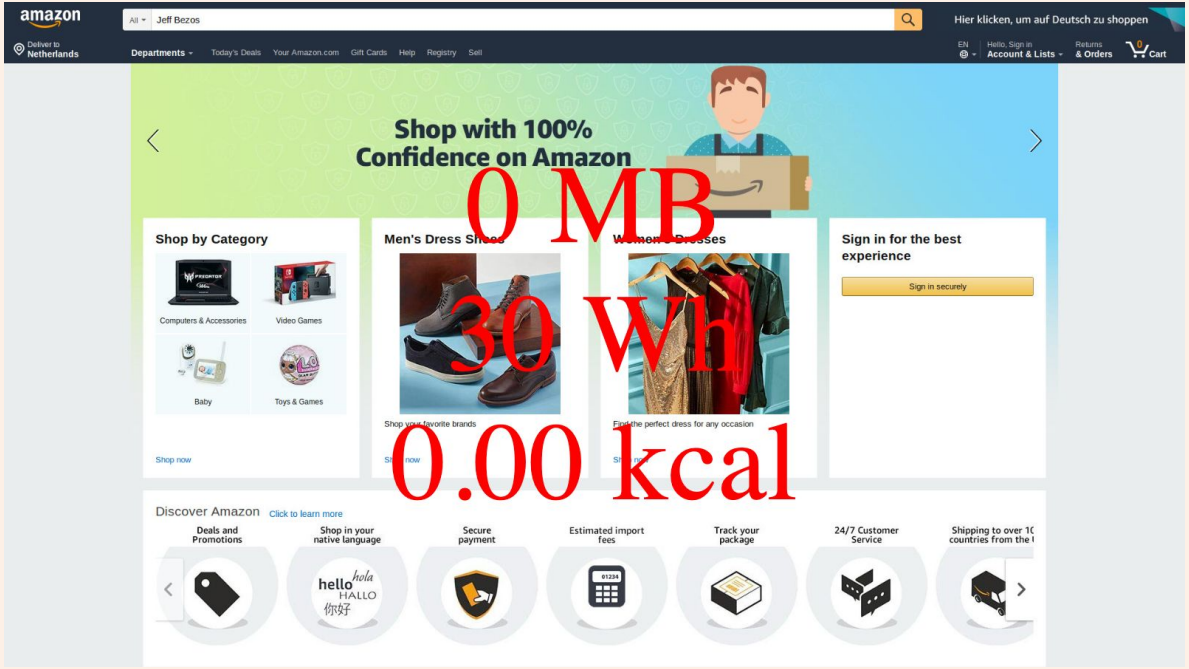
Where it gets complicated

Making a system visible is not the same as transforming it.

An artist does not control every condition.

What can this particular work change?

Joana Moll


amazon
Jeff Bezos
Hier klicken, um auf Deutsch zu shoppen
Deliver to Netherlands
Departments
Today's Deals
Your Amazon.com
Gift Cards
Help
Registry
Sell
Hello, Sign in
Account & Lists
Returns
& Orders
Cart
Shop with 100% Confidence on Amazon
0 MB
30 Wh
0.00 kcal
Shop by Category
Computers & Accessories
Video Games
Baby
Toys & Games
Men's Dress Shoes
Shop your favorite brands
Find the perfect dress for any occasion
Sign in for the best experience
Sign in securely
Shop now
Discover Amazon
Click to learn more
Deals and Promotions
Shop in your native language
Secure payment
Estimated import fees
Track your package
24/7 Customer Service
hello
hola
HALLO
你好



What scrolling into view looks like

For your practice…

Takeaway Question

Choose one current work.

What does the way you make and share it allow other people to understand or do?

What could you change to give them more room to examine, decide, or make something themselves?

Authorship does not disappear.

Your name helps organize how the work is understood.

Your particular encounter shapes what you can make.

Your contribution takes place within cooperation.

Your decisions can change how others encounter and participate in the work.

Calling a work yours

Your contribution can be real without being self-sufficient.

What have you shaped, decided, or made possible?

Thank You So Much!

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